

The Case of the Desert Star

Chelsea pressed her nose against the airplane window and frowned. Below, the world had turned from green to brown — miles and miles of sand-colored earth, dotted with scrubby bushes and strange, rocky hills.

"Where are all the trees?" she whispered to Sharkie, her stuffed shark, who was buckled into the seat beside her.

Daddio leaned over. "That's the high desert, Chels. Different things grow out there — you just have to look closer."

But Chelsea wasn't so sure.

When they landed in Albuquerque, the air smelled peculiar — like sage and something warm she couldn't name. Papa Puleo met them at the curb in a big truck, and Momma Karen had already set out sopaipillas drizzled with honey on the kitchen table. The honey was golden and tasted like wildflowers.

"Momma Karen, does anything actually grow out here?" Chelsea asked, licking her fingers.

Momma Karen smiled. "Go look in the backyard. But bring your magnifying glass."

Chelsea grabbed Sharkie and stepped outside. At first, she saw only dry ground and a few pale rocks. But then she knelt down. A tiny cactus, no bigger than her thumb, had a single pink flower blooming at its tip. She touched the petals — soft as Mamma's scarf.

She looked further. Between two flat stones, a lizard the color of cinnamon watched her with bright, curious eyes. Near the fence, a bush she'd almost ignored was covered in small silver leaves that shimmered when the wind blew — iridescent, like soap bubbles.

"Sharkie, look," she breathed. "Everything IS here. It's just... quieter."

That evening, while Mamma and Daddio ate enchiladas smothered in red and green chile — Christmas style, Papa Puleo called it — Chelsea drew a map of everything she'd discovered in the backyard. Seven tiny treasures she would have missed if she hadn't crouched down and paid attention.

Mr. Bugles popped up from behind the salt shaker. "I THOUGHT the desert was BORING but it turns out I was the boring one for not LOOKING!"

Everyone laughed, but Chelsea nodded quietly, because she understood something new: the most interesting places aren't always the loudest ones. Sometimes, the most wonderful things are waiting for someone brave enough to look closely.

What's something you almost missed because you weren't looking closely enough? What did you discover when you paid more attention?

Weekly Planner

F E B R U A R Y 8 - F E B R U A R Y 14 , 2026

*From sourdough and roast chicken on the coldest night to
Christmas enchiladas in the high desert — a week that warms
from the inside out.*

Week at a Glance

DAY	EVENTS	DINNER	ALBUM
Sun 02/08 OVERCAST 22°/14°	Dinner at friend's house — Philly Cheesesteaks	Philly Cheesesteaks	Butcher Brown – Solar Music
Mon 02/09 OVERCAST 25°/10°	—	Herb-Roasted Whole Chicken with Root Vegetables & Pan Gravy	Ambrose Akinmusire – honey from a winter stone
Tue 02/10 LIGHT DRIZZLE 45°/18°	Level 4 Swim Lessons 6:00-6:30 PM	Babo Pasta with Alfredo Sauce	Maria Mazzotta – Onde
Wed 02/11 OVERCAST 42°/30°	Elsie's afterschool science potions camp 3:45-4:45 PM	Warm Farro Salad with Roasted Beets, Goat Cheese & Walnuts	Adrianne Lenker – Bright Future
Thu 02/12 OVERCAST 37°/27°	Work Potluck for lunch — Dan making taco bar; Elsie's dance after school camp 3:45-4:45 PM	Shakshuka with Za'atar Sourdough Toast	Anouar Brahem – The Astounding Eyes of Rita
Fri 02/13 CLOUDY 38°/24°	Elsie YAT 4:30-6:00 PM; Laura Book Club (evening)	Lemon Ricotta Pancakes with Maple Breakfast Sausage	Say She She – Silver
Sat 02/14 SNOW 40°/27°	Flight details 4:30-5:00 AM; YAT 9:00 AM-12:00 PM (tentative); Valentine's Day	Christmas Enchiladas	Lara Manzanares – Voz de Río

Daily Plan

From American to New Mexican, with Butcher Brown on the stereo

Reflections & Practice

DAYS 3-5 · TUESDAY-THURSDAY (PRACTICE) Presence in the Rush

Midweek is the crucible. Swim lessons, science camp, dance camp — the days are full, and the adults' days are full of getting her there. It is tempting to treat these as obstacles between you and the weekend. But Epictetus taught that we suffer not from events but from our judgments about them. The judgment 'this is just a busy week before the real thing' robs Tuesday through Thursday of their own life. When you are at the pool, be at the pool. When you are driving, notice the road.

During one transition today — a car ride, a waiting room, a walk to the door — put your phone away and simply be where you are for two full minutes. What did you notice?

"Demand not that things happen as you wish, but wish them to happen as they do, and you will go on well." — Epictetus, Enchiridion, Section 8

DAYS 6-7 · FRIDAY-SATURDAY (INTEGRATION) Carrying Presence into the New

Friday night is packing; Saturday begins in darkness with a 4:30 AM flight. Everything about travel pulls you out of the present. Yet Seneca wrote that he was not born for one corner of the universe. The Stoic traveler carries presence onto the plane, into the rental car, through the door of a place she has never been. Valentine's Day coincides with your journey — love is not a place you arrive at but an attention you practice. As you land in Albuquerque, simply look. The light in New Mexico is unlike anywhere else.

As you arrive in Albuquerque, take one minute before reaching for your phone. Look at the sky, the mountains, the light. Write down three words that describe what you see — not what you expected to see, but what is actually there.

"I am not born for any one corner of the universe; this whole world is my country." — Seneca, Moral Letters to Lucilius, Letter 28

The Presence Jar

Place a small jar on the kitchen counter. Each time someone truly notices something — the taste of dinner, the sound of rain, a moment of eye contact — write it on a slip of paper and drop it in. On Friday night, while packing, read the slips aloud together.

This makes presence tangible and communal, transforming an abstract Stoic concept into a family game Elsie can lead.

Elsie's Explorer Eyes

Elsie, this week you're going somewhere brand new — Albuquerque, New Mexico! A very wise man named Marcus Aurelius said we should love what life brings us with all our heart. Here's a secret: the best explorers aren't the ones who've been to the most places — they're the ones who really look. This week, practice your 'Explorer Eyes.' Wherever you are — at swim, at science camp, at dance — pretend you're seeing it for the very first time. Then when you get to New Mexico, your Explorer Eyes will already be warmed up.

Being present means really seeing what's in front of you. When we pay attention, every place becomes an adventure.

The week ahead has routine and surprise, cold and warmth, the familiar and the utterly new. On Sunday you will shiver in Virginia; by Saturday night you will stand under the vast New Mexico sky. The same heart beats in both places. Pay attention. That is the whole of the practice.

OVERCAST 22°/14° · COLDEST DAY, GUSTY

Sunday, February 8

DINNER AT FRIEND'S HOUSE — PHILLY CHEESESTEAKS

Bundle up — it's 22°F with 43 mph gusts rattling the windows, a perfect excuse to head to a friend's house and let someone else do the cooking.

Philly Cheesesteaks

AMERICAN

The cheesesteak was born in 1930 when Pat Olivieri, tired of his own hot dogs, grilled sliced beef with onions on an Italian roll at the corner of 9th and Passyunk in South Philly. A passing cabbie tried one, told Pat to forget the franks, and an American icon was born. Tonight you get the real thing at a friend's table — no cooking required.

ribeye steak (from RD), provolone, hoagie rolls, onions

Pick up steak from RD. Sourdough bread is ready and resting for the week ahead.

AT THE TABLE

We're eating at a friend's house tonight — what's your favorite thing about sharing a meal with people outside our family? If you could invite anyone in the world to dinner, who would it be and what would you serve them?

Eating at a friend's home is a mini-adventure in trust and openness — you step into someone else's kitchen, their rhythms, their traditions. This question helps Elsie practice gratitude for the people who welcome us, and gently stretches her imagination about hospitality and generosity.

The Stoic Guide

PRESENCE

Present with Wonder

This week invites the family to practice radical presence — being fully here with the people you love, even as the world shifts around you. From the frozen stillness of a Virginia winter to the desert light of New Mexico, from the routines of swim lessons and science camp to the anticipation of Valentine's Day, every transition is an invitation to pay closer attention. The Stoics taught that the present moment is the only thing we truly possess. This week, we practice holding it gently.

"Accept the things to which fate binds you, and love the people with whom fate brings you together, but do so with all your heart."

— Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* Book 6, Chapter 39

This is a week of motion. Elsie moves from the pool to the science lab to the dance studio; Laura balances book club and packing; Dan holds the logistics together while the family hurtles toward a 4:30 AM flight. It would be easy to spend the whole week living in Saturday — mentally already in Albuquerque, already past the alarm clock, already somewhere else. The Stoics would gently ask: what are you missing right now? Marcus Aurelius wrote from military camps and imperial courts, places of enormous pressure. His answer was always the same: return to the present. Love the people in front of you. As temperatures climb from 10°F to 45°F and the landscape prepares to shift from Virginia pines to desert mesas, the family practices a three-part journey: awakening to presence, practicing it in the chaos of midweek, and carrying it into the wonder of a new place.

DAYS 1-2 · SUNDAY-MONDAY (AWAKENING) The Cold Clarity of Now

The week opens in bitter cold — highs barely cracking 22°F, the kind of weather that makes you want to retreat indoors. But cold has a gift: it makes you intensely aware of your body, your breath, the warmth of a house. The Stoics called this *prosoche* — attention. Before you can be present with others, you must notice that you are here. Let the cold sharpen your senses rather than dull your spirit. Notice the steam from your coffee, the weight of a blanket, Elsie's laughter from the next room.

What is one thing I can only experience right now — today, in this cold, in this house, with these people — that I will not be able to experience next week in New Mexico?

"Confine yourself to the present." — Marcus Aurelius, Meditations, Book 6, Chapter 32

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION The Freeze-and-Shave Technique — Partially freeze your ribeye for 20–45 minutes before slicing. This firms the meat just enough to get paper-thin cuts against the grain — the hallmark of an authentic Philly steak. Slice no thicker than 1/8 inch for maximum tenderness.

TEXTURE The Cheese Melt Debate — For the most authentic experience, lay your cheese (Cheez Whiz for classic, provolone for purist, white American for creamy) directly on the sizzling beef, then cover with a dome or foil for 15–30 seconds to trap steam and melt evenly. Never use cheddar or mozzarella — that's not Philly.

BUTCHER BROWN

Solar Music

2024 · JAZZ-FUNK · ENERGETIC, FUNKY, EXPANSIVE

Recorded at Montrose Recording in Richmond, VA with engineer Adrian Olsen, Solar Music is Butcher Brown's genre-defying manifesto — jazz, funk, hip-hop, and soul colliding in a five-piece collective that calls their sound 'everything under the sun.'

Jazz-funk fusion, heavy drums, wah-wah guitar, horn arrangements, progressive soul

Cheesesteaks deserve swagger, and this Richmond funk collective brings it. Plus they're playing The Atlantis in DC on March 13.

Reflection

Race to the Sun by Rebecca Roanhorse

A middle-grade adventure novel set in New Mexico, rooted in Navajo mythology. Nizhoni Begay, a seventh-grader, discovers she has ancestral powers and must go on a dangerous quest to save her family. It's brave, fast-paced, funny, and deeply tied to the land you're about to visit — the mesas, the sky, the stories that live in the desert.

Reading even a few chapters before the trip transforms Albuquerque from 'a place we're visiting' into 'the place where Nizhoni's story lives.' Elsie will look at the New Mexico landscape differently — and that's exactly what brave explorers do. They arrive with eyes already open.

This week is a masterclass in transitions — from the familiar rhythm of swim and camps to the wild unknown of a pre-dawn flight and a new city. The temptation is to compartmentalize: get through the week, then enjoy the trip. But Elsie doesn't see it that way. For her, Monday's roast chicken and Saturday's enchiladas are part of the same story. The science potions and the airplane are chapters in the same adventure. Your job this week isn't to manage logistics (though you will). It's to model wonder. When you're curious about the herbs on the chicken, playful about pancakes-for-dinner, and genuinely excited about stars at 3 AM, Elsie absorbs something no camp or class can teach: that the people who love her find the world endlessly interesting. That's the Valentine she'll remember.

You don't need to be a perfect parent — just a present one.

Monday, February 9

The coldest night of the week — 10°F low — and the house will fill with the scent of thyme, rosemary, and roasting bird. Stay in, stay warm.

Herb-Roasted Whole Chicken with Root Vegetables & Pan Gravy

FRENCH-AMERICAN

A whole chicken rubbed with herb butter, set atop a bed of carrots, parsnips, and potatoes, roasted until the skin crackles and the drippings pool into a simple pan gravy. Tear off hunks of Sunday's sourdough to sop up every last drop. This is the dinner Thomas Keller calls 'the benchmark of a cook.'

whole chicken, carrots, parsnips, potatoes, garlic, thyme, rosemary, butter, sourdough bread
Start the chicken at 5 PM for a 6:30 table. Save the carcass — tomorrow's broth starts tonight.

AT THE TABLE

This chicken is roasted with herbs that grow right out of the ground. If you were an explorer and could discover a brand-new plant that nobody has ever seen, what would it look like, what would it smell like, and what would you name it?

The smell of roasting herbs is one of those sensory anchors that makes a home feel safe. Connecting that warmth to nature and discovery lets Elsie flex her creativity while grounding the explorer theme in something she can taste and touch — a perfect Monday wind-down.

Nudges

The Explorer's Notebook

With science camp, dance camp, YAT performances, and an Albuquerque trip all landing in one week, Elsie's brain is absorbing more new experiences than usual. At eight, kids are just beginning to develop the ability to reflect on their own experiences — but they need a tangible tool to anchor that skill. A travel journal gives her a place to process, remember, and own her discoveries.

Give Elsie an 'Explorer's Field Notebook' — a small, sturdy journal she can carry all week. Each day she jots or draws one discovery: a science potion recipe, a dance move she nailed, a YAT moment that made her nervous, a funny thing someone said. By Saturday morning she'll board the plane with a whole week of bravery documented in her own handwriting.

1. Monday evening: Present the notebook with a little ceremony — 'Every great explorer keeps a field notebook. This one is yours.'
2. Each night before bed (or at dinner), ask: 'What goes in the notebook today?' Let her write, draw, or paste something in.
3. On the plane Saturday morning, flip through the week's entries together. It becomes a pre-trip ritual and a keepsake.

Valentine's Love Map

Valentine's Day falls on a 4:30 AM travel day, which means the usual card-and-candy celebration isn't going to work. But that's actually a gift in disguise. At eight, Elsie is in a key developmental window for understanding that love isn't just a feeling — it's something people do, consistently, in small and specific ways. A week-long trail of love notes teaches that better than any store-bought valentine ever could.

Create a 'Love Map' — seven small handwritten notes, one hidden each day in Elsie's world: her lunchbox, swim bag, science camp backpack, dance bag, YAT tote, and finally her carry-on for the flight. Each note names one specific thing you love about her. The final note, tucked into her bag with a small treat, arrives mid-flight on Valentine's morning — tying the whole week into a single thread of love.

1. Sunday night: Write all seven notes. Keep them short and specific — 'I love how you always check on your friends when they're sad' is better than 'You're great.'
2. Each morning, hide that day's note somewhere she'll find it during her activity (swim bag Tuesday, science camp backpack Wednesday, dance bag Thursday, YAT bag Friday).
3. Saturday's note goes in her carry-on with a small treat. When she finds it on the plane, it ties the whole week together.

The Early-Bird Adventure Pact

The 4:30 AM flight means waking around 3 AM — brutal for anyone, but especially for an eight-year-old whose body runs on routine. Sleep disruption is one of the most reliable triggers for meltdowns at this age. The antidote isn't just logistics (though those matter); it's narrative. If Elsie goes to bed Friday believing she's on a secret mission, the alarm becomes a plot point instead of a rude awakening.

Starting Wednesday, begin building the 'secret early-bird mission' storyline. Only the bravest explorers get to see an airport when the sky is still full of stars. Make a pact: first person to spot a star on the drive to the airport picks the first activity in Albuquerque. By Saturday morning, the early wake-up isn't something that happens to Elsie — it's something she chose to be part of.

1. Wednesday at dinner: Casually mention, 'Did you know our plane leaves before the sun is even up? Only night-owl explorers get to do that.'
2. Friday night: Pack together, lay out travel clothes, and let Elsie set her alarm clock. Give her ownership of waking up — she'll take it seriously.
3. Saturday morning: Keep lights low, voices soft, and have a small snack bag ready. Play her favorite quiet music in the car. Celebrate being awake with wonder, not stress.

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Overnight Dry Brine — The day before, pat the chicken completely dry and season generously with kosher salt mixed with ½ teaspoon baking powder. Place uncovered on a rack in the fridge for 12–24 hours. The next day, loosen the skin from the breast and thighs with your fingers and rub softened herb butter (thyme, rosemary, garlic) directly onto the meat.

TEMPERATURE High-Heat Start, Gentle Finish — Preheat oven to 450°F. Roast breast-side-up for the first 25 minutes at high heat, then reduce to 375°F for the remainder (about 45–55 minutes for a 4 lb bird). Let the chicken rest, loosely tented, for 15–20 minutes before carving.

SAUCE Proper Pan Gravy from Drippings — After roasting, transfer the chicken and vegetables out. Set the roasting pan over medium heat on the stovetop. Spoon off all but 2–3 tablespoons of fat, then whisk in 2 tablespoons flour. Cook the roux for 2 minutes, scraping up every browned bit. Gradually whisk in 1½ cups warm chicken stock and any collected juices. Simmer until thickened, then finish with a squeeze of lemon juice and a knob of cold butter swirled in off-heat.

AMBROSE AKINMUSIRE

honey from a winter stone

2025 · MODERN JAZZ · CONTEMPLATIVE,
WARM, WINTRY

Grammy-nominated for Best Alternative Jazz Album, Akinmusire's winter-titled record is atmospheric and emotionally searching — the trumpet floating over spare arrangements like breath visible in cold air.

Modern jazz trumpet, atmospheric textures, restrained rhythm section, spacious arrangements

A winter-titled jazz album for the week's coldest night. Trumpet warmth mirrors the thyme-scented air of a roasting kitchen.

Conversation Starters (continued)

THURSDAY — SHAKSHUKA WITH ZA'ATAR SOURDOUGH TOAST

"Shakshuka comes from North Africa and the Middle East — it's traveled thousands of miles to end up on our table! In just two days, we're flying to New Mexico. What are you most excited to discover there, and is there anything you're a little nervous about?"

This dish literally crossed continents to reach your kitchen — what a beautiful parallel for a family about to cross the country. Asking about both excitement and nerves gives Elsie full permission to hold two feelings at once, which is one of the most important emotional skills an eight-year-old can practice.

FRIDAY — LEMON RICOTTA PANCAKES

"You picked tonight's dinner — breakfast for dinner! If you were in charge of our family for a whole day and could flip any rules upside-down, what would you change? Pajamas to school? Dessert first? You're the boss!"

This is Dad-and-Elsie night while Laura is at book club, and Elsie chose this meal — so the whole evening is hers. Leaning into her sense of agency and playful power builds confidence and connection right before the biggest adventure day of the week. Let her lead. She's ready.

SATURDAY — CHRISTMAS ENCHILADAS

"We made it to Albuquerque! These enchiladas are served 'Christmas style' — half red chile, half green chile. If you had to describe today's adventure using only three words, what would they be? And what's one thing you saw today that you've never seen before?"

After a 4:30 AM flight and a day full of new sights, Elsie's brain is overflowing. The three-word constraint helps her distill a sensory-rich day into something she can hold onto. And it's Valentine's Day — so sitting together in a new place, sharing bold food and bold stories, is the best love letter this family can write.

LIGHT DRIZZLE 45°/18° · WARMEST DAY, GUSTY

Tuesday, February 10

6:00-6:30 PM | LEVEL 4 SWIM LESSONS

The warmest day at 45°F — practically a thaw. Make pasta together in the morning, let the dough rest in the fridge, then roll and cut before swim lessons.

Babo Pasta with Alfredo Sauce

ITALIAN

Handmade egg-yolk pasta in the Emilian tradition — yolks only, no whites — yielding golden, silky noodles with an almost custard-like richness. Tossed in a proper Alfredo of butter, cream, and Parmigiano-Reggiano. Fifteen minutes from boiling water to table.

spinach, egg yolks, flour, heavy cream, butter, Parmigiano-Reggiano, nutmeg

Make dough in the morning, rest in fridge. Boil water before leaving for swim — cook the moment you walk in the door.

AT THE TABLE

You just came from swim lessons — your body worked really hard tonight! What's something difficult you tried recently (in the pool or anywhere) that you're proud of, even if you haven't totally mastered it yet?

After swim, Elsie's body is tired and her defenses are down — which actually makes this the best moment for an honest conversation about effort. Comforting pasta creates a safe, warm space to reinforce that bravery isn't about being perfect; it's about showing up and trying, even when the water is cold.

Parenting Corner

Brave Explorers: Hearts & Horizons

This week is about courage in all its forms — tasting bold flavors at a friend's table, performing onstage at YAT, mixing mystery potions at science camp, leaping through dance camp choreography, and catching a pre-dawn flight to the Land of Enchantment. Valentine's Day falls on travel day, which means love isn't something we celebrate sitting still — it's something we carry with us into the unknown. Every dinner this week is a basecamp, and every conversation is a chance to remind Elsie that the bravest thing an explorer carries isn't a compass — it's an open heart.

Dinner Conversation Starters

SUNDAY — PHILLY CHEESESTEAKS

"We're eating at a friend's house tonight — what's your favorite thing about sharing a meal with people outside our family? If you could invite anyone in the world to dinner, who would it be and what would you serve them?"

Eating at a friend's home is a mini-adventure in trust and openness — you step into someone else's kitchen, their rhythms, their traditions. This question helps Elsie practice gratitude for the people who welcome us, and gently stretches her imagination about hospitality and generosity.

MONDAY — HERB-ROASTED WHOLE CHICKEN

"This chicken is roasted with herbs that grow right out of the ground. If you were an explorer and could discover a brand-new plant that nobody has ever seen, what would it look like, what would it smell like, and what would you name it?"

The smell of roasting herbs is one of those sensory anchors that makes a home feel safe. Connecting that warmth to nature and discovery lets Elsie flex her creativity while grounding the explorer theme in something she can taste and touch — a perfect Monday wind-down.

TUESDAY — BABO PASTA WITH ALFREDO

"You just came from swim lessons — your body worked really hard tonight! What's something difficult you tried recently (in the pool or anywhere) that you're proud of, even if you haven't totally mastered it yet?"

After swim, Elsie's body is tired and her defenses are down — which actually makes this the best moment for an honest conversation about effort. Comforting pasta creates a safe, warm space to reinforce that bravery isn't about being perfect; it's about showing up and trying, even when the water is cold.

WEDNESDAY — WARM FARRO & BEET SALAD

"At science potions camp today you mixed things together to see what happens. If you could mix any two things in the whole world together to create something totally new, what would you combine and what would it do?"

Science camp is still buzzing in her mind, so this question rides that wave of wonder. Letting Elsie invent something imaginary validates what she did at camp and stretches her thinking from 'what happened' to 'what could happen' — the heart of every brave explorer's mindset.

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Finish Pasta in the Sauce — Pull your fresh spinach pasta from the boiling water 30 seconds before it's done and transfer it directly into the skillet with melted butter. Reserve at least 1 cup of the starchy pasta water. Toss the pasta vigorously in the butter, adding splashes of pasta water and handfuls of finely grated Parmigiano-Reggiano, tossing constantly until a glossy, emulsified sauce coats every strand.

TEXTURE The Warm Bowl Technique — Warm your serving bowl (or tossing pan) before building the sauce — run it under hot water or place it in a low oven. Never build the sauce in a screaming-hot pan. Medium-low heat is your friend; if the pan is too hot, the cheese will clump into rubbery strands instead of melting into silk.

ACID Black Pepper & Nutmeg Finish — Just before serving, crack fresh black pepper generously over the pasta and grate a whisper of fresh nutmeg on top. Use a Microplane for the nutmeg — you want a dusting, not a dose.

MARIA MAZZOTTA

Onde

2024 · ITALIAN FOLK · HEARTFELT,
MEDITERRANEAN, EARTHY

Recorded at Sudestudio in Italy and winner of the Premio Loano for best traditional album, Onde blends Salento pizzica rhythms with post-rock guitars. Guest spots include Nigerien desert-blues guitarist Bombino.

Italian folk vocals, pizzica rhythms, accordion, frame drum, Mediterranean instrumentation

Italian pasta deserves real Italian music — not Sinatra, but Puglian frame drums and a voice that channels the Southern coast.

Wednesday, February 11

3:45-4:45 PM | ELSIE'S AFTERSCHOOL SCIENCE POTIONS CAMP

Midweek calm. Elsie's at Science Potions Camp until 4:45 — roast the beets while she's gone, then assemble dinner together when she's home.

Warm Farro Salad with Roasted Beets, Goat Cheese & Walnuts

MEDITERRANEAN

Warm farro — the ancient Tuscan grain — tossed with roasted golden and red beets, crumbled goat cheese, toasted walnuts, arugula, and dried cranberries, all dressed in a sherry-maple vinaigrette. Substantial, earthy, and ready in the time it takes to cook the grain.

farro, golden beets, red beets, goat cheese, walnuts, arugula, dried cranberries, sherry vinegar, maple syrup

Roast beets during camp. Farro takes 25 minutes — start when she walks in. Assembly is fast.

AT THE TABLE

At science potions camp today you mixed things together to see what happens. If you could mix any two things in the whole world together to create something totally new, what would you combine and what would it do?

Science camp is still buzzing in her mind, so this question rides that wave of wonder. Letting Elsie invent something imaginary validates what she did at camp and stretches her thinking from 'what happened' to 'what could happen' — the heart of every brave explorer's mindset.

Family Corner

Conversation starters, parenting nudges, and connection ideas

Prep-Ahead Checklist

- ☐ Saturday (Feb 7): Thaw chicken if frozen. Bake sourdough bread.
- ☐ Sunday: Pick up steak from RD. Sourdough ready for the week.
- ☐ Monday morning: Take chicken out 1 hour before roasting.
- ☐ Monday evening: After dinner, start chicken broth with carcass.
- ☐ Tuesday morning: Make babo pasta dough (spinach + egg yolks + flour). Rest in fridge.
- ☐ Tuesday afternoon: Roll and cut pasta before swim lessons.
- ☐ Wednesday during science camp: Roast beets (45 min at 400°F).
- ☐ Thursday morning: Prep taco bar for work potluck — brown beef, shred lettuce, pack shells + sour cream + guac.
- ☐ Friday afternoon: Pre-measure pancake dry ingredients. Set out ricotta and lemons.
- ☐ Friday evening: PACK FOR ALBUQUERQUE. Bags by the door. TSA docs ready.
- ☐ Friday evening: Download Lara Manzanares album for the plane.

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Toast the Farro in Butter — Before boiling, melt 1 tablespoon of butter in a saucepan over medium heat. Add the rinsed farro and stir constantly for 2–3 minutes until the grains darken slightly and release a fragrant, nutty aroma. Then add chicken stock (instead of water) with a sprig of thyme and simmer until al dente — tender but still pleasantly chewy.

PREPARATION Roast Beets Properly — Scrub the beets, trim the tops, and wrap each beet individually in foil with a drizzle of olive oil and a pinch of salt. Roast at 400°F for 45–60 minutes until a knife slides through with no resistance. Let cool in the foil (they steam and loosen their skins), then rub the skins off with a paper towel. Cut into wedges.

ACID Warm Sherry-Maple Vinaigrette — Whisk together 3 tablespoons sherry vinegar, 1 tablespoon maple syrup, 1 teaspoon Dijon mustard, and a minced shallot. Stream in ¼ cup extra-virgin olive oil while whisking. Warm the vinaigrette gently in a small pan (don't boil) and toss it with the warm farro immediately — warm grains absorb dressing far better than cold ones.

TEXTURE Last-Minute Assembly — Toss the warm dressed farro with roasted beet wedges and dried cranberries. Arrange on a platter over fresh arugula (the residual heat will just barely wilt it). Scatter generous crumbles of goat cheese, toasted walnut pieces, and finish with flaky salt and a final drizzle of olive oil.

ADRIANNE LENKER

Bright Future

2024 · INDIE FOLK · INTIMATE, GENTLE, LUMINOUS

Recorded at Double Infinity studio in the Massachusetts mountains with Nick Hakim on piano, Bright Future is Grammy-nominated folk at its most intimate — fingerpicked guitar, whispered vocals, and the unhurried patience of a snow day.

Acoustic guitar, fingerpicking, intimate vocals, lo-fi warmth, folk minimalism

An earthy grain salad on a quiet Wednesday calls for music that's equally unhurried — Lenker's gentle folk mirrors the meal's honest simplicity.

Grocery List

PRODUCE	GRAINS & PASTA
• carrots • parsnips • potatoes (2 lbs) • garlic (2 heads) • onions (3) • spinach (6 cups baby) • bell peppers (2) • lemons (4) • arugula (2 bags) • golden beets (2) • red beets (2) • cherry tomatoes (1 pint) • blood oranges (3) • radicchio (1 head) • Brussels sprouts (1 lb) • fresh thyme • fresh rosemary • fresh parsley • shallots (2)	• farro (1 cup) • flour (2 cups) • sourdough bread (from Sunday batch) • hoagie rolls (Sunday) • pita bread • taco shells (for potluck)
PROTEIN	PANTRY
• whole chicken (4 lbs — use from fridge) • eggs (2 dozen) • breakfast sausage links (1 package) • ribeye steak (from RD for Sunday)	• canned tomatoes (28 oz) • harissa paste • za'atar • cumin • paprika • nutmeg • baking powder • maple syrup • sherry vinegar • champagne vinegar • Dijon mustard • anchovy paste • capers • dried cranberries • olive oil (good EVOO) • honey • cinnamon • cayenne • vanilla extract • cocoa powder
DAIRY	NUTS & SEEDS
• whole-milk ricotta (15 oz) • heavy cream (1 pint) • Parmigiano-Reggiano (wedge) • butter (2 sticks) • feta cheese (8 oz) • goat cheese (4 oz) • burrata (1 ball) • Pecorino Romano (small wedge) • cream cheese (4 oz) • sour cream (for potluck taco bar)	• walnuts (1/2 cup) • hazelnuts (1/4 cup) • pistachios (1/4 cup)
	POTLUCK TACO BAR
	• ground beef (2 lbs) • taco shells • sour cream • guacamole (or avocados to make) • shredded lettuce • taco seasoning

Thursday, February 12

	WORK POTLUCK FOR LUNCH — DAN MAKING TACO BAR
3:45-4:45 PM	ELSIE'S DANCE AFTER SCHOOL CAMP
<i>A lighter evening after the potluck lunch. Dance camp pickup at 4:45, then a one-skillet dinner that practically cooks itself.</i>	
Shakshuka with Za'atar Sourdough Toast	
MIDDLE EASTERN / NORTH AFRICAN	
Shakshuka — eggs poached in a spiced tomato-pepper sauce fragrant with cumin, paprika, and harissa. The dish traces to the Maghreb, where its Arabic name simply means 'a mixture.' Thick slices of Sunday's sourdough, rubbed with za'atar and olive oil, are the only utensil you need.	
eggs, canned tomatoes, bell peppers, onion, garlic, cumin, harissa, za'atar, sourdough bread, feta cheese	
<i>Light dinner after heavy potluck. One skillet, minimal cleanup. Uses Sunday's sourdough.</i>	
AT THE TABLE	<i>Shakshuka comes from North Africa and the Middle East — it's traveled thousands of miles to end up on our table! In just two days, we're flying to New Mexico. What are you most excited to discover there, and is there anything you're a little nervous about?</i> This dish literally crossed continents to reach your kitchen — what a beautiful parallel for a family about to cross the country. Asking about both excitement and nerves gives Elsie full permission to hold two feelings at once, which is one of the most important emotional skills an eight-year-old can practice.

Beverage Pairings

Côtes du Rhône

Medium-bodied Grenache-Syrah-Mourvèdre blend with red fruit, herbs, and gentle spice. Versatile enough for chicken, pasta, or cheesesteaks. Look for Guigal or Chapoutier (\$12-16).

An everyday red that pairs with the widest range of this week's dinners.

Sparkling Water with Blood Orange & Rosemary

Sparkling mineral water with muddled blood orange, rosemary sprig, and lime squeeze. Refreshing, zero-proof, and ties into the winter citrus theme.

Kid-friendly and festive without alcohol. Ties into the winter citrus salad theme.

Mexican Hot Chocolate

Rich hot cocoa with cinnamon, a pinch of cayenne, vanilla, topped with whipped cream or marshmallows. Warming for cold February nights.

Ties into New Mexico travel theme. Kid-approved. Perfect for 20°F evenings.

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Bloom Spices & Build the Base — Slowly caramelize diced onions until golden (8–10 minutes — don't rush this). Add diced peppers and cook until softened. Clear a space in the center of the pan, add a tablespoon of harissa paste and your ground cumin and paprika directly to the hot oil, and stir for 60 seconds until fragrant before incorporating them into the vegetables.

SAUCE Simmer to the Trail Test — After adding crushed San Marzano tomatoes, simmer the sauce for 15–20 minutes until it thickens enough that dragging a spoon across the bottom leaves a trail that holds for 2–3 seconds before closing. If it's too watery, the eggs will poach unevenly; if too thick, they'll fry instead of poach.

TEMPERATURE Ramekin Egg Drop & Covered Poach — Crack each egg into a small ramekin first. Use a spoon to make deep wells in the sauce, then gently slide each egg from the ramekin into its well. Cover the skillet with a lid and reduce heat to medium-low. Poach for 5–7 minutes — whites should be fully set but yolks still jiggle. Remove from heat 30 seconds early; residual heat finishes the job.

ACID The Finishing Layer — Off heat, crumble feta generously over the shakshuka, drizzle with good extra-virgin olive oil, and scatter fresh herbs (parsley or cilantro). For the za'atar toast, brush thick sourdough slices with olive oil, sprinkle liberally with za'atar, and broil until golden and fragrant.

ANOUAR BRAHEM

The Astounding Eyes of Rita

2009 · ARABIC JAZZ / CHAMBER ·
MEDITATIVE, HYPNOTIC, LUMINOUS

Released on ECM, Brahem's oud quartet merges Arabic maqam traditions with jazz and chamber music. Klaus Gesing's bass clarinet weaves around the oud like smoke — hypnotic, meditative, impossible to rush.

Oud, piano, accordion, double bass — sparse and spacious chamber jazz with Middle Eastern modalities

North African comfort food deserves music from the same world. Brahem's Tunisian oud creates the meditative atmosphere shakshuka was made for.

Appetizers

Warm Baked Ricotta with Lemon & Herbs
Whole-milk ricotta baked until golden and slightly puffed, finished with lemon zest, fresh herbs, cracked pepper, and good olive oil. Served with sourdough crostini.
ricotta cheese, lemon, thyme, olive oil, sourdough bread

Whipped Feta Dip with Roasted Red Peppers & Za'atar
Feta whipped with cream cheese, lemon, and garlic until fluffy, topped with roasted red peppers, olive oil, and za'atar. Served with warm pita.
feta cheese, cream cheese, roasted red peppers, za'atar, lemon, pita

Salads

COMPOSED DINNER

Winter Citrus & Radicchio Salad
Composed arrangement of blood orange and cara cara segments, shaved radicchio, burrata, pistachios, and Castelvetro olives.
Dressing: Blood orange vinaigrette: fresh blood orange juice, champagne vinegar, Dijon mustard, EVOO, minced shallot, flaky salt, honey
Bitter radicchio tamed by sweet citrus and creamy burrata. The vinaigrette brightens every bite. Follows the Italian principle of balancing amaro with dolce and grasso.

SIDE

Shaved Brussels Sprout Slaw with Pecorino & Hazelnuts
Thinly shaved Brussels sprouts tossed with shaved Pecorino Romano, toasted hazelnuts, and a bright lemon-anchovy dressing.
Dressing: Lemon-anchovy dressing: fresh lemon juice, anchovy paste, Dijon mustard, EVOO, garlic, salt, pepper
Umami from anchovy and Pecorino meets the mild bitterness of raw Brussels sprouts. Lemon brightens, hazelnuts add toasty warmth.

SIDE

Simple Arugula & Parmesan with Lemon Vinaigrette
Peppery arugula with shaved Parmigiano-Reggiano, lemon, and the best olive oil you have. The 3-minute side salad that elevates any dinner.
Dressing: Fresh lemon juice, EVOO, Maldon salt, cracked black pepper
Arugula's pepperiness softened by the nuttiness of Parmigiano and fruity acidity of lemon. Every ingredient pulls its weight.

Friday, February 13

4:30-6:00 PM
EVENING

ELSIE YAT
LAURA BOOK CLUB

Friday fun night — Laura's at book club, so it's Dad and Elsie in the kitchen. Pack for tomorrow's 4:30 AM flight while the pancakes cool.

Lemon Ricotta Pancakes with Maple Breakfast Sausage
AMERICAN (BREAKFAST-FOR-DINNER)

Fluffy ricotta pancakes brightened with lemon zest and juice, served with real maple syrup and pan-seared breakfast sausage. The ricotta pancake tradition traces to Sephardic Jews in medieval Southern Italy — tonight it's Elsie's choice, and she's flipping.

ricotta cheese, lemons, flour, eggs, maple syrup, breakfast sausage, butter, baking powder
Elsie's pick! Let her measure and flip. Pack bags for Albuquerque before bed — 4:30 AM comes fast.

AT THE TABLE

You picked tonight's dinner — breakfast for dinner! If you were in charge of our family for a whole day and could flip any rules upside-down, what would you change? Pajamas to school? Dessert first? You're the boss!

This is Dad-and-Elsie night while Laura is at book club, and Elsie chose this meal — so the whole evening is hers. Leaning into her sense of agency and playful power builds confidence and connection right before the biggest adventure day of the week. Let her lead. She's ready.

Kitchen & Pantry

Appetizers, salads, beverages, and your shopping list

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Whipped Egg White Soufflé Lift — Separate your eggs. Mix the yolks into the batter with ricotta, lemon zest, lemon juice, and dry ingredients. In a separate clean bowl, whip the egg whites to soft peaks, then fold them into the batter in two additions — first addition to lighten, second to preserve the air. Mix only until just combined; streaks of white are fine.

ACID Zest Over Juice — Zest 2 lemons directly over the batter bowl using a Microplane — this captures the volatile citrus oils at their freshest. Add the juice of 1 lemon. Use only fresh lemons, never bottled juice. The zest is where 80% of the lemon flavor lives.

TEXTURE Butter-Oil Griddle & Small Pours — Heat a nonstick skillet or griddle over medium heat (not medium-high). Use a mix of 1 tablespoon butter and 1 teaspoon neutral oil per batch. Pour ⅓-cup portions and resist the urge to press or spread the batter — let it find its own shape. Flip when bubbles appear on the surface and edges look set (about 2–3 minutes).

SAY SHE SHE

Silver

2024 · INDIE SOUL / FUNK · JOYFUL,
GROOVY, UPBEAT

Recorded live to tape at Killion Sound in North Hollywood by producer Sergio Rios, Silver is Brooklyn disco-soul with a conscience — Motown harmonies, Chic-inspired grooves, and lyrics tackling everything from bodily autonomy to feminist art.

Three-part harmonies, disco-funk bass, vintage keys, Motown-inspired arrangements with indie sensibility

Breakfast-for-dinner is a celebration, and Say She She's disco-funk will have Elsie dancing at the stove. They're at 9:30 Club on Feb 17.

CHEF'S TIPS

PREPARATION Order Christmas Style, Stacked — When the server asks 'red or green?', say 'Christmas' — this gets you both red and green chile sauce on the same plate, half and half. Ask for your enchiladas 'stacked' rather than rolled, which is the authentic New Mexican style: tortillas layered like lasagna with cheese and chile between each layer, topped with a fried egg.

PREPARATION Ask About the Chile Heat — Before ordering, ask your server how hot the green chile is today — it varies by season, batch, and restaurant. If dining with Elsie, request 'mild' or 'medium' and get a side of hot sauce to adjust. Also ask for sopapillas (puffy fried bread) with honey on the side — they're the traditional New Mexican dessert-with-dinner and perfect for cooling the heat.

LARA MANZANARES

Voz de Río

2023 · NEW MEXICO INDIE FOLK · WARM,
STORYTELLING, ROOTED

Manzanares is a northern New Mexico native from a sheep-ranching family whose bilingual folk won Album of the Year at the New Mexico Music Awards. Her songs are sonic postcards from the Land of Enchantment — listen on the plane.

Acoustic guitar, bilingual vocals (English/Spanish), folk arrangements, New Mexico folk traditions

Flying to New Mexico? Start the experience at 30,000 feet with music from an Albuquerque native whose bilingual folk captures the exact landscape below.

Saturday, February 14 — Valentine's Day

4:30-5:00 AM	FLIGHT DETAILS
9:00 AM	YAT -12:00 PM
	VALENTINE'S DAY

Valentine's Day in the high desert. You woke at 3:30 AM, flew west, and landed in a city where the question isn't 'how are you?' — it's 'red or green?'

Christmas Enchiladas

NEW MEXICAN

New Mexico stacked enchiladas smothered Christmas style — half red chile (deep, smoky, earthy) and half green chile (bright, tangy, sharp). The name doesn't come from the holiday; it comes from a server's suggestion to a customer who couldn't choose. Order with a side of sopapillas and carne adovada.

blue corn tortillas, red chile sauce (Hatch), green chile sauce (Hatch), cheese, chicken or beef, fried egg

Valentine's dinner in Albuquerque! Try Cocina Azul or Sadie's. Don't skip the sopapillas.

AT THE TABLE

We made it to Albuquerque! These enchiladas are served 'Christmas style' — half red chile, half green chile. If you had to describe today's adventure using only three words, what would they be? And what's one thing you saw today that you've never seen before?

After a 4:30 AM flight and a day full of new sights, Elsie's brain is overflowing. The three-word constraint helps her distill a sensory-rich day into something she can hold onto. And it's Valentine's Day — so sitting together in a new place, sharing bold food and bold stories, is the best love letter this family can write.